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THE HILL MIGRATION TRAP

WHY PEOPLE LEAVE UTTARAKHAND'S HILL VILLAGES

Migration, farm livelihoods and the search for a livable future in Uttarakhand's hills

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This is a desk-based manuscript. It uses published research and public institutional sources; it does not present new interviews or a fresh village-level survey.

READER'S NOTE

What this manuscript can—and cannot—claim

This book looks at rural out-migration in parts of Uttarakhand, including Jaunsar-Bawar, Chakrata and the Tehri region, and at the relationship many families have with Dehradun and other towns. It brings together research on migration, agriculture, care, rural services, tourism and public programmes. It is written for general readers, students, community organisations and people involved in development or local administration.

It is not a completed field investigation. No original interviews were conducted for this manuscript, and it contains no newly collected village-level measurements. Where a published study is discussed, its sample and geographic scope are stated so that its results are not mistaken for statewide findings. Where the text proposes a tool, scorecard or five-year action plan, that material is a recommendation for testing—not an existing government commitment.

The difference matters. A persuasive story about an empty house can draw attention to a problem, but it cannot establish how many people have moved, why a family left, or whether a scheme worked. Those questions need dated records, clear definitions and direct evidence. They also need conversations with residents who stayed, residents who left and people who returned.

How to use the evidence

The strongest local conclusion usually comes from more than one source: census or administrative records, published research, local-service data and accounts from residents. Each source has blind spots. Administrative registers may miss seasonal movements; surveys may cover only a small number of households; interviews describe experience but do not automatically represent a whole district. None should be asked to answer a question it was not designed to answer.

Two published studies anchor the manuscript. Hoffmann and colleagues' 2019 paper examined 100 migrant households in Dehradun and analysed land-cover change in two villages of origin. Lakhera, Kumar and Tripathy's 2025 paper studied adherence to homestay guidelines among 155 operators. Both are useful, but neither is a census of Uttarakhand. Their findings are described with those limits in mind. [1, 2]

INTRODUCTION

A state of beautiful villages and empty homes

A house can look abandoned and still belong to a family that returns every year. Another may have someone living in it while the village around it has lost its school, its bus connection or the people who once organised everyday work. From the road, these differences can be hard to see. They matter a great deal to the people who live with them.

The phrase “ghost village” has become familiar in discussions of Uttarakhand. It captures the unease of seeing homes locked and fields left uncultivated, but it can also make very different places appear identical. A settlement with no permanent residents is not the same as one where older people remain while working-age adults live elsewhere. Nor is seasonal movement the same as permanent relocation. Before the label can guide policy, the underlying condition has to be described properly.

Migration itself is not proof that a village has failed. People move for education, employment, marriage, healthcare, family reasons and personal ambitions. Money earned elsewhere may pay school fees, fund repairs or support relatives who remain at home. A city can open opportunities that were not available locally. The concern begins when moving becomes the only realistic way to obtain basic services or earn a reliable income, especially for people who would prefer to remain closer to their land and community.

This is not a simple rural-versus-urban story. The 2019 study by Hoffmann and colleagues, based on interviews with 100 migrant households in Dehradun, found that education, employment and income, and access to facilities featured prominently in the reasons people gave for moving. Environmental problems were often recognised as village problems, but they were much less prominent as personal reasons for migration. The authors also examined land-cover changes in two villages of origin; their results did not support a simple, general claim that deforestation was the principal driver of the migration they studied. The sample was limited, but the lesson is useful: an explanation that sounds convincing is not necessarily the explanation households themselves give. [1]

The book therefore asks four practical questions. What makes people leave? What changes for those who remain? Under what conditions does returning make sense? And which economic activities or public programmes help people build a secure life rather than deliver a short burst of activity followed by disappointment?

There is no single answer for every village. A settlement with dependable road access and a strong market connection faces different choices from one where travel is slow, services are distant and farms are difficult to manage. The right response has to start with local conditions. The goal is not to persuade everyone to stay. It is to make staying, leaving and returning genuine choices.

CHAPTER 1

The empty house is not the whole story

Before a place is described as emptying, its residents, household patterns and services need to be counted carefully.

What do we mean by an “empty” village?

The phrase can refer to several different things: a settlement with no permanent residents; a village whose population has fallen over time; or a place where younger adults live elsewhere while parents, children or other relatives remain. The differences are not semantic. They change what a sensible response might look like.

A locked home, for instance, may be used during festivals or agricultural seasons. A family may keep its land but live in Dehradun during the school year. Another household may have left permanently because it could not reach a school, health facility or dependable source of income. Counting houses alone would miss these distinctions.

A useful village profile should therefore separate permanent residents from seasonal occupancy, record the age structure of the population, count households still engaged in farming, and note whether essential services are actually usable. “Available” should mean more than a building on a map. A clinic that opens irregularly, a bus that no longer matches school hours, or an internet connection that fails through much of the day may provide little practical access.

What the published research tells us

Hoffmann, Konerding, Nautiyal and Buerkert’s 2019 study is one of the more directly relevant published sources for rural-to-urban migration into Dehradun. The researchers interviewed 100 migrant households, covering 24 neighbourhoods in the city and 69 villages of origin. They asked people about their own reasons for moving as well as the reasons they believed people generally moved. They also analysed land cover in two villages. [1]

Education, employment opportunities, income and facilities were among the reasons respondents commonly identified. Environmental conditions were frequently described as problems in villages, but they were rarely volunteered as the personal reason for a household’s move. The study also found that the land-cover story was more complicated than a simple claim of widespread deforestation: the two villages showed fluctuations, with forest cover increasing in recent years, while district- and state-level forest cover was described as relatively stable in the analysis.

This does not establish that environmental conditions never cause migration. It means only that the study’s respondents, in the places and period it covered, more often spoke about socioeconomic opportunity than environmental decline as the direct reason for moving. The sample cannot represent every household in Uttarakhand. Still, any account of migration that ignores what migrants say about their own decisions is incomplete.

A regional problem, not a single story

Jaunsar-Bawar, Chakrata and the Tehri region share some broad challenges of mountain geography and uneven access to services. They are not interchangeable. Travel time, road reliability, land quality, water availability, market distance, tourism demand and the strength of local institutions differ from settlement to settlement. A policy that is effective in one place may do little in another.

The Uttarakhand Rural Development and Migration Prevention Commission's public website discusses population change using comparisons between the 2001 and 2011 Census periods and notes slow or negative growth in several hill districts. Those figures are important historical context; they should not be presented as a current village-level count. The Commission's page itself is a starting point for research, not a replacement for newer records or local verification. [3]

A profile is most useful when it records the source and year of every figure and explains what is being counted: individuals, households, usual residents or seasonal occupants. It should show travel time and cost to school, healthcare, public transport, markets and digital services. Where records are incomplete, the gap should be named. Guessing creates false confidence; admitting uncertainty gives the next survey a clear job to do.

Bring the findings back to residents

A survey should not end when the spreadsheet is complete. Residents need a chance to correct errors, explain seasonal patterns and say which service gaps affect daily life most. Their accounts do not replace administrative records, but records should not be treated as infallible either. The point is to check both against each other.

Ultimately, the question is not simply whether people have left. It is whether they had a realistic choice. A village can remain populated while its residents face serious barriers to work and services. Another can have fewer permanent residents but retain strong family, economic and cultural links. Population figures are essential; on their own, they do not tell the whole story.

CHAPTER 2

Why young people leave

A move is often a practical decision about work, education, cost and what a household can reasonably expect at home.

The economics of moving

For many young adults, the map of opportunity is uneven. Colleges, specialist healthcare, salaried work, vocational training and larger markets tend to be concentrated in towns and cities. Dehradun is a destination for people looking for options that may be difficult to reach from a remote settlement. That does not mean every city job is secure or every village livelihood is unviable. It means the available choices are not evenly distributed.

The financial comparison is rarely as simple as a village wage against a city salary. Rent, food, transport, debt payments and the cost of travelling home can swallow a substantial share of earnings. City work may be irregular; village income may be seasonal but supplemented by food grown at home or a house that does not require rent. Some forms of value are easy to count. Others are not. A fair comparison should include both, while avoiding the assumption that non-cash benefits make up for every income gap.

A household's decision may involve several generations. Parents may help a child move for college, even when they would prefer that the child return. One sibling may earn a wage in Dehradun while another looks after land or an older relative. Remittances can improve family finances, but care and labour do not travel as easily as money does.

Schools, healthcare and everyday services

Education can determine where a family lives long before a job offer arrives. If a student must relocate to complete secondary education, access a specialised course or attend university, the move can become a family decision. Healthcare can have a similar effect. A local facility may handle routine needs, while specialist treatment involves travel, accommodation and time away from paid work.

Transport and connectivity influence nearly every other decision. A farmer needs to move produce, a student needs to reach class, a patient needs to reach care and a remote worker needs dependable power and internet. When these systems fail, separate inconveniences begin to add up. The existence of a school, clinic or road is not enough; operating hours, service quality, cost and reliability matter too.

It is easy to describe out-migration as a loss of attachment to the village. That explanation is often too blunt. People can value their home, language, land and community and still decide that their prospects are better elsewhere. Attachment does not pay tuition fees or ensure timely treatment. The question for policy is what makes the local option workable, not how to make young people feel guilty about leaving.

Migration has costs, but it can also create options

Leaving can bring higher earnings or a stronger educational path. It can also mean insecure work, high housing costs, separation from family and limited social support. People who remain may inherit extra agricultural work, childcare or care for older relatives. These consequences vary by income, age, gender and the arrangements within each household; one person's account should not be made to stand in for everyone else.

Circular and seasonal migration deserve attention too. Some people may want to work in a city for part of the year and return for farming, family responsibilities or a local enterprise. Such a pattern is not necessarily a failed attempt to settle permanently. With safe transport, accessible services and reliable information about work, movement between places can be part of a durable household strategy.

A simple household budget can clarify the trade-offs. Record take-home earnings, rent, food, transport, debt, healthcare, remittances and the cost of travelling home. Add unpaid work and any income that is seasonal or uncertain. The calculation will never capture every benefit—education and professional experience matter too—but it is better than comparing a city salary with a village income and stopping there.

What local planning can do

Local measures should focus on reducing avoidable disadvantages: more dependable transport connections, clear information about jobs and training, access to employment advice, predictable healthcare and practical support for older people. None of these measures will persuade everyone to remain. That is not the test. The test is whether families can make their decisions with better options and fewer preventable risks.

CHAPTER 3

When farming stops paying

The issue is not simply whether a crop will grow, but whether the work can support a household at a fair and dependable return.

Production is not the same as income

Agriculture remains central to the lives and household economies of many hill communities. Yet the ability to grow a crop does not automatically make farming profitable. Plots may be small or fragmented; slopes and distance can make mechanisation difficult; and carrying produce to a buyer may cost more than the farmer first expects. Labour shortages can make routine tasks harder to sustain.

The relevant figure is net return. That means looking beyond the price received to include seed and other inputs, hired and family labour, transport, packaging, storage, spoilage, credit and the farmer's time. A crop can suit local conditions and still provide a poor cash return if buyers are unreliable or the quantity available is too small to justify the trip to market.

The calculation should be repeated across seasons. A good harvest or an unusually high market price can hide a weak business model. Crop losses, illness, a road disruption or a fall in demand may change the result quickly. Food grown for the household has real value even when it generates little cash; that value should be recorded separately rather than confused with commercial profit.

Risk, labour and local conditions

Farmers in different parts of Uttarakhand face different combinations of water constraints, wildlife damage, labour availability, weather variability and market access. These pressures should be documented for the locality rather than presumed to affect every village in the same way. A farm near a reliable road and buyer operates under different conditions from one with steep fields and a long journey to market.

It is also important to ask who does the work and who controls the money. Women may carry a substantial share of farm and household responsibilities, particularly where younger adults or men are away for employment. A programme that increases output while adding unpaid work may look successful in a production report and still leave household welfare unchanged or worse.

Traditional crops and locally adapted practices may have ecological, nutritional and cultural value. Those qualities can create a commercial opportunity, but they do not guarantee a premium price. Buyers may require a consistent volume, quality, packaging and delivery schedule. Farmers need evidence that a market exists before they invest in certification or processing.

Organic farming: a route, not a guarantee

Organic and natural farming programmes are part of Uttarakhand's agricultural policy landscape. The state Agriculture Department describes support for training, certification, farmer clusters and marketing under programmes listed on its official website. [4] Such support can help, but a policy

listing does not prove that every farmer can access it or that a particular crop will become more profitable.

Certification, records, aggregation, packaging, transport and marketing all take time and money. The shift to a new system can also affect yields and labour requirements differently by crop and location. Before asking farmers to change production methods, a project should identify likely buyers, expected volumes, product specifications, payment periods and who will absorb the loss if a shipment is rejected.

A farmer cluster can be helpful when it gives members something concrete: shared equipment, a buyer relationship, better transport terms or access to training that would be costly for a single household. But a cluster formed mainly to receive a grant may not survive once the funding ends. Members need clear rules for quality checks, prices, payment, record-keeping and disputes.

Processing only helps when it solves a real problem

Drying, grading, packaging or other processing can reduce spoilage or make transport easier. It can also introduce new expenses: energy, equipment maintenance, staff, compliance, packaging and unused capacity outside the harvest season. A feasibility assessment should compare the net return from raw produce with the net return from the processed product. More steps do not automatically mean more value.

Start with a modest trial. Identify a buyer, agree on a quantity and quality standard, record the costs, and review how long payment takes. Ask the farmers who chose not to participate why they stayed away; ask those who left what went wrong. These answers can be more useful than a high enrolment number.

A sound rural strategy should improve farm returns where agriculture is viable and help households diversify where it is not. That is less dramatic than promoting one miracle crop, but it gives farmers a better chance of making decisions with open eyes.

CHAPTER 4

The people who remain

When one person leaves, the work and care that remain do not disappear. Someone else usually has to take them on.

How a household reorganises

Migration rarely affects every member of a household in the same way. Older residents may continue looking after land, livestock and property. Women may take on farming, childcare and care for relatives while staying in contact with family members elsewhere. Children may grow up with a parent working away. These are possible patterns, not assumptions that should be applied to every family.

Remittances can pay for education, healthcare, repairs and farm inputs. That money matters. It does not replace daily assistance when someone is ill, or the time required to maintain a house and fields. A household may be financially better off after migration and still face more loneliness, heavier workloads or difficulty getting help in an emergency.

This is why income statistics alone cannot describe the full effect of migration. But an account focused only on separation and loss is incomplete too. Moving can give people independence, qualifications and a measure of financial security that was unavailable at home. A careful account has to make room for both experiences.

Services and community life

When a village's population declines, local institutions may come under pressure. A school may have fewer pupils, a shop fewer customers or a bus service less demand. Community events and collective maintenance can become harder to organise when fewer residents are present. These effects are not inevitable: some villages continue to sustain active social networks despite out-migration.

The practical question is how to maintain essential services without pretending that every service can be delivered in exactly the same way everywhere. Shared facilities, scheduled mobile provision, transport assistance or coordinated service days may help in some places. They need dependable staff, clear timing and someone responsible when the service fails. A facility that exists only on paper is not a solution.

Planning should include people who live in the village and those who have moved away. Former residents may offer skills, contacts, investment or help with local initiatives. They should not be treated as a substitute for public responsibility, however, and residents who remain should have a decisive voice in choices affecting everyday life.

Knowledge is part of the story, not the whole answer

Farming practices, food preparation, forest knowledge, building methods, festivals and local institutions are often learned through repeated contact across generations. When younger people spend less time in the village, some of those opportunities may diminish. Migrants can also help

preserve and share knowledge by returning for festivals, supporting archives or introducing new skills.

Documentation should be voluntary and respectful. People who share a seed practice, recipe, local name or oral history should have a say in how it is recorded, credited and used. Private or sacred practices should not be turned into tourism products without community agreement.

There is a further point worth taking seriously: young people may value local knowledge and still choose a different occupation. Cultural continuity should offer a way to learn, not impose a duty to repeat the lives of earlier generations. Better services and meaningful work remain necessary. Tradition cannot be asked to compensate for the absence of either.

Listen to the people who do not call migration a crisis

Some residents value the income and independence migration brings. Others would prefer to stay if suitable work or reliable services were available. A village-level discussion that assumes everyone wants to return will not hear either group properly. Ask who wants what, what constraints people face, and which forms of support they consider useful.

Meetings should lead to decisions people can track. Record which requests were accepted, which were declined, the reasons and the date for review. Participation is not meaningful simply because people attended a meeting. It matters whether their views changed the plan—or whether officials explained clearly why they did not.

CHAPTER 5

Reverse migration: who comes back, and why?

A return is durable only if the household can make a living and use essential services after the first enthusiasm fades.

Return is not a single event

The phrase “reverse migration” covers several different situations. Someone may return temporarily after losing a job, come back each season to work on the farm, run a village business while keeping city clients, or move permanently with the entire household. These patterns cannot be measured with one registration date, and they should not be treated as equivalent outcomes.

The COVID-19 pandemic brought public attention to people returning to rural areas, but a return during a crisis does not, by itself, show that a new livelihood has become viable. A useful assessment follows households over time: did people remain when immediate pressure eased, did their income stabilise, and could their family reach school, healthcare and other essential services?

Research should include people who returned and stayed, those who left again, and those who considered returning but decided against it. Looking only at the successful entrepreneur or the family that settled back home can create a misleading picture. The reasons another household abandoned a plan may reveal the exact gaps that a programme needs to address.

The assets people bring—and the constraints they meet

Returnees may bring savings, professional skills, digital experience, contacts or knowledge of supply chains. Those assets can matter, but they do not remove the limits of geography, infrastructure, finance or local demand. A food business needs reliable ingredients, packaging, delivery and customers. A farm needs suitable land, water, labour and buyers. A homestay needs guests beyond the peak season, and enough revenue to cover maintenance.

Support should begin with a small feasibility exercise, not a promise of success. Who is the customer? What problem is the business solving? What will people pay? Which permissions are required? How much working capital is needed, and how long might it take before cash flow becomes reliable? The assumptions should be backed by some evidence—a customer conversation, a pilot order, or a small test—not simply optimism.

Mentors can help returnees review costs, compliance, marketing and risk. Their job is not to guarantee success or take control of the enterprise. It is to identify problems early enough that a household can adjust before using up its savings.

The decision belongs to the household

A person may want to return while a partner worries about school options or healthcare. Children may need to finish an academic year. An older relative may need regular specialist treatment. A plan that counts only the prospective entrepreneur’s job will overlook the circumstances that determine whether the whole household can relocate.

Hybrid arrangements may be a sensible first step: remote work with periodic visits to the city, a seasonal enterprise alongside wage employment, or one family member staying in town during the school year. These are not necessarily failures. They may help a household test whether a more permanent move is practical.

Before a move, households can list expected income, premises or land needs, working capital, customer acquisition, transport, education, healthcare and the likely time needed to cover costs. A short trial or part-time operation may be safer than committing all savings at once. The appeal of returning is real, but so are the bills that arrive after it.

What should success look like?

A return strategy should respect those who want to live elsewhere as well as those who want to come home. Success is not the number of people who publicly announce an intention to return. It is whether a household can maintain a viable income and access the services it needs—and whether it remains by choice, not because it has run out of alternatives.

Local institutions can help connect returnees to producer groups, experienced operators, banks, buyers and public services. The same support should be available on fair terms to residents who never left. A village economy is not strengthened when newcomers are favoured at the expense of existing households.

CHAPTER 6

Homestays: tourism income or a seasonal promise?

A room is not a livelihood until there is enough demand to pay its costs and a fair share of the income stays local.

Measure the business, not just the building

Homestays can connect visitors with local food, accommodation, guiding, transport and cultural knowledge. They may create paid work beyond the property itself. Yet tourism potential is not the same as dependable income. Demand changes with season, weather, road conditions, travel trends and the location of the property. A room occupied for a handful of busy weeks may not cover annual maintenance, utilities, staff time, repairs and debt.

The basic questions are straightforward, even if the answers take effort: how many nights were sold, at what average rate, what did it cost to host guests, how much money remained after expenses, and how uneven was the income across the year? Registration counts can help an administrator track programme reach, but they are not a measure of whether the businesses are financially healthy.

Owners should estimate revenue under low, typical and peak-season occupancy rather than build a plan around the best few weeks. Costs may include cleaning, laundry, food, utilities, maintenance, booking commissions, applicable fees, staff time and loan repayment. Furniture and plumbing wear out too; replacement costs should not be ignored simply because they do not arrive every month.

What the 2025 homestay study actually found

Lakhera, Kumar and Radha Tripathy published a study of Uttarakhand's homestay guidelines in the journal Discover Sustainability in September 2025. In Dehradun district, the authors conducted in-depth interviews with 155 homestay owners in February 2023, complemented by observation techniques. The article reports variation in how operators followed different guideline categories and found positive correlations between reported guideline adherence and several economic-development indicators. [2]

Those results are relevant, but they need to be read carefully. The sample was not every homestay in Uttarakhand. The study concentrated on operators' adherence and perceptions; it did not include the perspectives of tourists, local communities and government officials. Its cross-sectional design also limits claims about cause and effect. A positive correlation does not prove that compliance alone caused higher income or employment.

The useful implication is more modest: guidelines and support may matter, and implementation deserves scrutiny. It is not evidence that every supported homestay becomes profitable or that tourism delivers benefits evenly across a village. Local data are still needed.

Check the policy before giving advice

Government rules are not static. At the time of this editorial review, the Uttarakhand Tourism homestay registration portal displayed a self-declaration referring to Government Order 53 vi (1)/2026 dated 5 June 2026. The declaration says the property covered by the application must be in a rural area

and the applicant must be a permanent resident of Uttarakhand. The Tourism Department also lists more than one homestay-related programme, so anyone seeking registration should confirm which category and rules apply to their property before making an investment. [5]

This is a practical issue, not fine print. A business plan based on an outdated rule can leave an owner with costs that are difficult to recover. Public information should therefore state the date it was checked and link directly to the current official order or portal.

Keeping more of the money in the area

A homestay is more likely to support the wider local economy when it buys food from nearby farms, hires local guides, uses local transport and pays local workers for real work. These links do not happen automatically. Operators, farmer groups and guides can agree on seasonal supplies, clear rates and payment terms. Such arrangements should be voluntary, transparent and open to more than a small circle of well-connected businesses.

Tourism can also impose costs: pressure on water, waste disposal, traffic, housing, quiet spaces and public paths. A destination should not be promoted simply because it photographs well. Before marketing a village to new visitors, planners should check basic sanitation, drinking water, waste collection, safe access and community consent.

A useful local report could track paid workdays, the share of purchases made from nearby suppliers and the seasonal spread of bookings. Aggregate figures can show whether tourism spending is reaching the community without exposing individual business accounts. The purpose is not to maximise guest numbers at any cost. It is to find out whether tourism works for the people who live there.

Homestays should remain one option among several. Some places may have a credible visitor market; others may be better served by farming, food processing, digital services or access to nearby employment. The business model should follow local conditions, not the other way around.

CHAPTER 7

Rebuilding the rural economy

A strong plan begins with what a place can sustain and what real customers or service users need.

Start with assets and demand

Rural development plans often begin with an attractive list of possible projects: organic farming, tourism, food processing, crafts or digital work. The harder—and more useful—first step is to ask what the area can produce consistently, which skills already exist, what buyers want, what services are missing and how much it costs to reach a market.

Different villages will need different combinations. One may have visitor demand and people interested in guiding; another may have a suitable crop and a group of farmers willing to coordinate; a third may have dependable connectivity and workers with skills that employers need. A plan should not force every settlement into the same scheme just because a model worked somewhere else.

A community asset map can record land, water, existing skills, small businesses, transport links, public facilities, seasonal constraints and potential buyers. It should also identify places and practices residents do not want commercialised, as well as areas where additional visitors or production could cause harm. The map is there to support decisions, not to turn every local resource into an economic product.

Test a small idea before building a large project

Demand testing need not be expensive. A farmer group can approach prospective buyers with samples and a realistic volume estimate. A homestay operator can trial a guided walk with an existing accommodation package. A digital-work centre can speak to employers before buying equipment. The goal is to learn what customers will actually use or pay for before committing to fixed costs.

Shared farmer facilities can help with sorting, grading, packaging, storage or transport, but only when they solve an identified problem. Collective action also needs rules. Members should know who checks quality, how prices are decided, when payments are due, how operating expenses are shared and what happens if a shipment is rejected. Clear arrangements may seem mundane, but they prevent conflicts that can destroy trust.

Processing is not automatically profitable. It may extend shelf life or reduce transport losses, but it can also require electricity, trained staff, repairs, packaging and compliance. Compare the net return from selling raw produce with the return after processing. If a small pilot cannot cover its recurring costs, scaling it up is unlikely to solve the problem.

Digital work needs a connection to real work

Remote work is often presented as a way for young people to earn without leaving home permanently. Some can do so, but the option is not available to everyone. Many roles require qualifications, language and communication skills, dependable power, good internet and access to clients. A shared

workspace can help with equipment or quiet working space, but a building does not create jobs on its own.

Training should be linked to identified opportunities: verified vacancies, paid assignments, apprenticeships, customers or local firms with a real need for online services. Outcomes should be tracked beyond course completion. Did participants obtain paid work? Did the work continue several months later? Were payments timely? Were working conditions acceptable? These questions tell a programme more than a certificate count.

Digital services can also support existing enterprises. A farmer group may need online sales and bookkeeping; a homestay may need booking management; a local producer may need packaging design and customer communication. Those are modest but practical links between local activity and wider markets.

Diversification without overloading households

A village economy is usually more resilient when it has several sources of income, but diversification should not mean that every household is expected to do everything. It means people can specialise and still trade with one another. Visitors may buy meals from local producers; a farm cluster may employ people seasonally for sorting and packing; a digital worker may help a local business manage sales.

These links should be tested rather than assumed. Tourism, agriculture and small enterprises may compete for labour, water, transport or working capital. Each proposed intervention should name its intended beneficiaries, start-up costs, risks, local partners, expected timeline and measures of success. It should also say what will happen when initial public funding ends.

Review the portfolio annually. Record which households benefit, how many months of work are provided, what income or services result, what local purchases are made, and what problems persist. A project that repeatedly loses money should be changed or stopped. Continuing it only because money has already been spent is not a strategy.

CHAPTER 8

Government schemes and the limits of the evidence

A programme has to be judged by what changes for people—not just by the number of applications, registrations or assets delivered.

Inputs, outputs and outcomes are different things

Public programmes can provide finance, training, infrastructure, technical advice or access to markets. Each may be useful. But the existence of a scheme does not prove that it has improved livelihoods or reduced migration. Evaluation needs to separate inputs, outputs, outcomes and longer-term effects.

Money, staff and training resources are inputs. People trained, properties registered or equipment supplied are outputs. Increased net income, more months of paid work, improved farm sales or a business still operating after support ends are outcomes. Longer-term effects may include greater household security or a change in the pattern of migration. Those are not interchangeable measures.

A programme can meet its output target and still deliver little lasting benefit. A small project can help households in ways that a simple beneficiary count misses. To understand the difference, agencies need a baseline, an agreed definition of success and follow-up over a reasonable period. Where possible, compare supported participants with their earlier situation and with similar households that did not receive support, while being cautious about selection effects.

What the official migration material can tell us

The Uttarakhand Rural Development and Migration Prevention Commission publishes information about rural migration and reverse migration and provides a public route for suggestions and engagement. Its background page refers to changes between the 2001 and 2011 Census periods, noting slow growth across many hill districts and absolute population decline in Almora and Pauri Garhwal in that period. [3] These are historical, district-level observations. They should not be used as though they were a current count of every village or a direct measure of the causes of migration.

Administrative data should be read alongside local evidence. Before quoting a number, check the publication date, definition, district coverage and whether it counts individual migrants, households, seasonal workers or longer-term moves. A broad district trend can alert us to a question; it does not answer every village-level question.

Review homestay and farming support on their own terms

Homestay and organic-farming schemes connect local resources with possible income, but the results depend on implementation, eligibility, training, infrastructure and market access. The Agriculture Department's official page describes organic and natural farming programmes and lists activities such as training, certification and marketing support. That page documents programme information; it is not by itself an evaluation of net income or long-term environmental outcomes. [4]

For homestays, useful measures include occupancy by season, net earnings, local purchasing, paid work and business survival after support ends. For agriculture, look at net farm income, the price received, input and labour costs, crop losses, payment delays and whether participants continue after

the project period. Shared measures can include youth and women's participation, job quality and residents' views.

The 2025 homestay study found positive associations between guideline adherence and several economic-development indicators among the operators studied, but its cross-sectional data cannot establish that guideline compliance caused those outcomes. The authors also identify limitations, including the absence of views from tourists, local communities and officials. That does not make the study unhelpful; it tells us where further evidence is needed. [2]

A practical five-year plan

In the first year, establish a baseline for a small number of willing villages. Record population and household patterns, livelihoods, transport and service access, land use, connectivity and resident priorities. Explain how the information will be used, collect only what is necessary and protect personal details.

During years one and two, test a few locally appropriate pilots. Each needs a plausible business or service model, named local partners, realistic costs, a demand assessment and a way to measure results. The point is to learn before expanding, not to announce a large target before knowing whether the model works.

In years two and three, improve shared infrastructure or institutions where the pilot evidence supports it. This could mean better market links, storage, transport coordination, internet access or tourism services. Training should match work that is actually available. By years three to five, independent review should determine what deserves expansion, what needs redesign and what should end.

The action plan should name a responsible institution for every activity, as well as the partners, funding source, maintenance responsibility, baseline, deadline and reporting frequency. Residents should be able to see what was completed, what slipped and who is responsible for the next step.

Do not treat migration itself as the only score

A programme should not be called successful simply because people remain in the village, nor a failure simply because some leave. The measure is whether people have more realistic choices and whether the intended benefits reach them. A young person who obtains a safe, skilled job in a city may have improved their prospects; another who works remotely from home may also have done so; a returnee may build a viable enterprise. Different paths can all represent progress.

Results should include uncertainty and failure. If the data cover only registered businesses, informal activity may be missing. If an interview sample is small, it cannot establish statewide impact. If an enterprise succeeds during a strong tourism season, the result may not hold in a weak one. Publishing limits does not weaken an evaluation; it shows readers what can reasonably be concluded.

CONCLUSION

Staying should be a real choice

Migration is not a problem in itself. People move to study, work, care for family, explore different lives or pursue opportunities unavailable at home. Money sent back can support a household, and experience gained elsewhere can strengthen a local business. A policy that treats all movement as failure confuses freedom of choice with rural decline.

The more difficult issue is compulsion: people leaving because there is no dependable access to work, education, healthcare, transport or another basic service. A village may still have residents while offering them very few options. Another may have a smaller permanent population and still maintain strong social and economic links. Numbers matter, but they need context.

The research reviewed for this manuscript also cautions against easy explanations. In the 2019 study of migrant households in Dehradun, socioeconomic opportunities featured more prominently in people's personal accounts of migration than environmental decline. That finding does not mean environmental conditions are irrelevant to rural life. It means that the causes of a move should be established with evidence, not inferred from a single visible change in the landscape. [1]

Rural renewal will require dependable services and viable livelihoods. Farming needs market access and a fair return where local conditions support it. Tourism needs honest cost calculations, responsible growth and stronger local links. Digital work needs skills, connectivity and real employers. Public programmes need transparent rules and evaluation. Community organisations should have a meaningful role, but they should not be expected to replace the responsibilities of the state.

Different villages will need different combinations. One may benefit most from transport and healthcare improvements; another may have a sound basis for farming or tourism; a third may need better market connections before a new enterprise can survive. The sensible starting point is a short list of the barriers residents say matter most, supported by local evidence.

A yearly village scorecard could track household income sources, months of paid work, farm sales, active businesses, travel time to essential services, reliability of transport and connectivity, resident satisfaction and participation in planning. Migration can remain one measure among several, but it should not dominate the assessment. A fall in population may reflect education-related movement; a rise in income may reflect one unusually good season; a small enterprise may provide an essential service without employing many people. The numbers need an explanation.

The standard is not whether every young person stays. It is whether a young person who wishes to stay can find a credible path; whether a farmer can sell produce without losing money on the journey; whether an older resident can reach healthcare; and whether a returnee can test an enterprise without facing avoidable barriers. A village is not preserved by asking people to endure poor options. Its future improves when more options are genuinely available.

RESEARCH NOTES AND REFERENCES

The following sources were checked during the editorial review on 21 October 2026. References support the specific descriptions attributed to them; they do not automatically validate every general observation or recommendation in the manuscript.

Core research and official sources

[1] Hoffmann, E. M., Konerding, V., Nautiyal, S., & Buerkert, A. (2019). Is the push-pull paradigm useful to explain rural-urban migration? A case study in Uttarakhand, India. PLOS ONE, 14(4), e0214511. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0214511

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[3] Rural Development & Migration Prevention Commission, Government of Uttarakhand. Official website, including background material on rural migration and reverse migration. https://www.uttarakhandpalayanayog.com/home.aspx

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[5] Uttarakhand Tourism Department / Uttarakhand Tourism Development Board. Homestay policy information and current registration portal. On 21 October 2026, the registration page displayed a self-declaration referring to Government Order 53 vi (1)/2026 dated 5 June 2026; check the exact category and order before relying on eligibility information. https://homestay.uttarakhandtourism.gov.in/signup Policy page: https://www.homestay.uttarakhandtourism.gov.in/homestay-policy

[6] UOCB official portal. Institutional profile and organic farming information. The page and related government sources use variations in the organisation's English expansion; the acronym is retained here to avoid implying a name not consistently shown across pages. https://uocb.org/about/

[7] Himalayan Environmental Studies and Conservation Organisation (HESCO). Public profile of Dr Anil Prakash Joshi and HESCO's resource-based rural development work. https://hesco.co.in/about-us-2/

[8] Institute for Social and Economic Change (ISEC). Public faculty profile for Professor Sunil Nautiyal, whose listed research areas include natural-resource management, land-use/land-cover change and sustainable livelihoods. https://www.isec.ac.in/sunil-nautiyal/

Researchers and institutions to consult

The names below are research leads based on published work or institutional profiles; this list is not an endorsement, and no views should be attributed to these individuals unless supported by their own publications or statements.

- Dr Ellen M. Hoffmann and co-authors: migration choices and rural–urban connections in Uttarakhand; see reference [1].
- Professor Sunil Nautiyal, Institute for Social and Economic Change: natural-resource management, conservation, landscape change and sustainable livelihoods; see reference [8].
- Dr Anil Prakash Joshi, HESCO: community-based, local-resource-oriented rural development; see reference [7].
- Kapil Lakhera, Sushant Kumar and Radha Tripathy: homestay guidelines and rural tourism in Uttarakhand; see reference [2].
- Uttarakhand Rural Development & Migration Prevention Commission: official reports and administrative material for follow-up research; see reference [3].